

as a strong leader capable of providing a decisive government. But instead, he was among the first to call Manmohan Singh and Congress leader Sonia Gandhi to congratulate them on their performance, even assuring support in the running of the Lok Sabha.

So what next for Advani? He made it clear at the BJP's Parliamentary Board meeting on the evening of May 16 that he wished to step down and that the party should elect another Leader of the Opposition. The party has not accepted this and is trying to persuade him to continue. Advani's proposal of stepping down has not come as a surprise. With the results out, he wants to take a bow gracefully, even if as not a winner. He is expected to pull back from active party politics, making way for the next generation of leaders. However, BJP leaders, including some of the GenNext and those from the RSS, believe that he will continue as the arbiter within the party and the NDA. "There is nobody else with his kind of experience in the BJP. The role hitherto played by Atal Bihari Vajpayee will have to be played by Advaniji," avers a party leader.

In the coming days, as party leaders sit down for the post-mortem, the recrimination and finger-pointing will soon begin. How the party responds to the defeat will go a long way in deciding its future. Whether they take it in their stride and go ahead in building the party and resetting their agenda, or they get stuck in the blame-game of the vanquished and wallow in the mire, handing over a bigger victory to the Congress. The party has to begin from what went wrong for them, and what went right for the Congress. There are many within the BJP who believe that the party failed to come up with a clear message for the electorate, and it also failed to convey it properly.

With Rajnath's tenure as BJP president ending in late 2009, the party will have to decide on its next leader. Also, the differences among GenNext leaders need to be sorted out. Modi, whose name cropped up as the alternate prime ministerial candidate during the polls, is still not acceptable to some of the BJP's allies. Most importantly, the BJP has to decide if it wants to continue with its Hindutva agenda or give it up to take a more centre of right position in politics. Advani paid for this continued ambiguity within the party. It will now require sincere introspection, clear reasoning and judgement on part of the BJP to its way forward.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

PRAKASH KARAT

Lesser Carat

It was comrade general secretary's maiden run into the wilds of national politics proper. After taking over the CPI(M) which was revelling in its numerical arrogance as the pillar of the UPA Government almost four years ago, Prakash Karat is now struggling to keep the last post of the Brotherhood in Red. With voters rejecting his party even in trophy states like West Bengal and Kerala and the Third Front once again fizzling out, Karat has now been reduced to resident commissar of A.K.G. Bhavan. The CPI(M) seats have come down to 16, even less than its tally in 1967 when the fledgling party first contested polls. Even its strongholds like Kannur and Vadkara in north Kerala, the CPI(M) has lost badly. The soviets of West Bengal crumbled as the ghosts of Nandigram revenged against the CPI(M) for mixing the compulsions of the market economy with the excellence of the party's own rural thugs.

KARAT HAS NOW BEEN REDUCED TO RESIDENT COMMISSAR AT THE CPI(M) HEADQUARTERS

REUBEN SINGH



WHILE MANY OF THE FORMER GENERAL SECRETARIES EXCELLED AS SOCIAL COMMENTATORS AND POLITICIANS, KARAT REDUCED HIMSELF TO A POLICY WONK AND RELUCTANT MEDIATOR.